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California bill could ban food dye in schools. Are food dyes harmful? - According to the bill, snacks like Cheetos, Doritos or any other item containing 6 certain dyes might be unsafe to eat

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The Food and Drug Administration lists the food dyes Blue 1, Blue 2, Green 3, Red 40, Yellow 5 and Yellow 6 as safe to eat and use within the United States.

However, the FDA notes that some research suggests certain individuals may be sensitive to food dyes. Most individuals, though, have no adverse effects when consuming those food dyes.

But a new bill, introduced earlier this week, could ban food dyes in California schools. Here's what you should know about the bill — and food dyes.

What is the food dye bill in California?

As a follow-up to the California Food Safety Act, or FSA, Assembly Bill 2316 was introduced on Tuesday. The bill aims to ban artificial food dyes associated with hyperactivity and behavioral issues from being served in public school breakfasts and lunches, according to Food Safety Magazine.

Blue 1, Blue 2, Green 3, Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6 and titanium dioxide would be prohibited if the bill goes into effect.

In 2023, when the FSA was signed into law, food chemicals potassium bromate, propyl paraben, BVO and Red 3 were banned from being sold, delivered or manufactured in the state, per EWG.

Why is the food dye bill directed at students and children?

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, who sponsored the legislation, said in a press release, "California has a responsibility to protect our students from chemicals that harm children and that can interfere with their ability to learn."

According to NPR, advocates for the new legislation cite a potential association between artificial dyes and child development issues as grounds for prohibiting these additives in schools. However, critics in the food industry argue that there is insufficient scientific evidence to support this correlation.

What do health experts say about food dyes?

According to The Washington Post, "There is no evidence that ingesting red dye No. 3 or any other artificial food colors causes cancer in humans. Scientists, however, tend to use results of animal studies to understand possible effects in people."

Michael Hansen, a senior scientist for advocacy at Consumer Reports, told Everyday Health, "The law states that if a food additive or color additive has been shown to cause cancer in animals or humans, then it is not allowed into the food supply."

Studies show that cancer may occur in animals after eating food dyes. The FDA has not regulated any of them in our foods, Hansen told Everyday Health.

In a study published and produced by Center for Science and the Public Interest, researchers tested food dyes

individually (including Blue 1, Blue 2, Green 3, Red 40, Yellow 5 and Yellow 6).

Noting that each dye in their testing, except Orange B, causes tumors in kidneys, bladders, parts of the brain and other areas in animals, the study finds food dyes to be unsafe.

"Furthermore, virtually all the studies tested individual dyes, whereas many foods and diets contain mixtures of dyes (and other ingredients) that might lead to additive or synergistic effects," the study said.

Blue 1

Also known as Brilliant Blue, Blue 1 was originally made from coal tar. Now it is typically derived from an oil base, per Scientific American.

Possible problems with Blue 1

According to a research review published in the journal Advances in Nutrition, Blue 1 is found not to cause DNA damage or mutations within the body. However, there have been numerous cases that report negative effects for some individuals, including:

* Gastrointestinal tumors.

* Convulsion.

* Attention deficit and hyperactivity in children.

* Allergic reactions with preexisting asthma.

What foods contain Blue 1?

According to Functional Nutrition Answers, foods containing Blue 1 include:

* Candy.

* Canned peas.

* Cereal.

* Enteral nutrition formulas.

* Flavored applesauce.

* Food colorings.

* Ice cream.

* Icing

* Popsicles.

* Salad dressing.

* Smoked salmon.

* Flavored yogurts.

Blue 2

Blue 2 is created by heating indigo with sulfuric acid. The solution is then purified to obtain the dye. However, indigo used today is often synthetic and not produced from natural plants, according to Lancaster Online.

Possible problems with Blue 2

In group animal studies, Blue 2 did not affect reproduction or cause birth defects. However, male rats that received a lot of Blue 2 had increases in brain cancer and abnormal cell development, per Live Strong.

What foods contain Blue 2?

According to Functional Nutrition Answers, foods that contain Blue 2 include:

* Baked goods.
* Candy.
* Cereal.
* Drinks.
* Ice cream.

Green 3

Green 3, also known as a triphenylmethane color, is typically used for green or turquoise colors, per Cosmetics Info.

Possible problems with Green 3

According to a study published by the Center for Science in the Public Interest, exposure to Green 3 in mice and rats caused bladder tumors.

Reviewing multiple published research reviews or studies, EWG found Green 3 to be of low concern. However, there was some data on adverse neurobehavioral outcomes in children and cancer.

What foods contain Green 3?

According to Functional Nutrition Answers, foods that contain Green 3 include:

* Candy.
* Canned vegetables.
* Cereal.
* Drinks.
* Jello.
* Salad dressings.

Red 40

Red 40 is a bright red dye made out of the chemical compound Allura red AC, according to Web MD.

Possible problems with Red 40

Per Healthline, Red 40 is linked to aggression and mental disorders like attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder.

What foods contain Red 40?

According to a previous article published in the Deseret News, common foods that contain Red 40 include:

* Soda.

* Energy drinks.

* Sports drinks.

* Breakfast cereals.

* Yogurt.

* Flavored milk.

* Ice cream.

* Jello.

* Pudding.

* Protein powders.

* Powdered drink mix.

* Candy.

* Gummies or fruit snacks.

* Popsicles.

* Chips.

* Pastries.

Does red dye 40 cause hyperactivity in kids? Here's everything we know

Yellow 5

According to WebMD, Yellow 5, also known as tartrazine, creates a bright "lemon-yellow" color in foods and products.

Possible problems with Yellow 5

Per Verywell Health, believed reactions due to Yellow 5 include:

* Hives.

* Angioedema: swelling of the throat, neck, lips and tongue.

* Asthma.

* Skin rashes related to allergies.

* Food intolerances.

What foods contain Yellow 5?

According to Functional Nutrition Answers, Yellow 5 may be in:

* Baked goods, especially those with yellow filling.

* Candy.

* Cake.

* Cereal.

* Chips.

* Cookies.

* Cotton candy.

* Drink mixes.

* Frosting.

* Gumballs.

* Jello.

* Nacho cheese.

* Paella mix.

* Pickles.

* Banana peppers.

* Popcorn.

* Popsicles.

* Pudding or custard.

* Soda.

* Sports drinks.

Yellow 6

Yellow 6 is an artificial dye derived from petroleum, per EWG.

Possible problems with Yellow 6

According to Switch Nutrition, Yellow 6 could cause:

* Nasal congestion.
* Hives.
* Allergies.
* Kidney tumors.
* DNA damage.
* Hyperactivity.
* Abdominal pain.
* Headaches.
* Migraines.
* Vomiting.
* Nausea.
* Hormonal changes.

What foods contain Yellow 6?

According to Functional Nutrition Answers, foods that contain Yellow 6 include:

* Baked goods, especially those with yellow filling.
* Bouillon.
* Candy.
* Cake.
* Cereal.
* Chips.
* Cookies.
* Gumballs.
* Jello.

* Nacho cheese.

* Popcorn.

* Popsicles.

* Pudding or custard.

What are some popular foods that contain these artificial dyes?

If you choose to stay away from these six dyes, here is a compiled list from Functional Nutrition Answers and Healthline of foods that contain them.

* Air Heads.

* Cap'N Crunch.

* Cheetos.

* Doritos.

* Fritos.

* Frosted circus animals.

* Fruit Loops.

* Gatorade.

* Jolly Ranchers.

* Lucky Charms.

* M&Ms.

* Otter Pops.

* Ruffles.

* Starbursts.

* Toaster Strudel.

* Vanilla sugar wafers.

Certain brands listed above offer various flavors or alternatives. Some of these options may be dye-free. Review the nutrition label to identify the specific dyes present in each food product.

As a reminder, according to the FDA, food dyes typically do not pose significant health risks for the majority of individuals. However, knowing the risks may enhance your overall health, per Healthline.

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